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‘I fear the Pandit’s articles reveal practically no acquaintance with Islam’

Muhammad Iqbal and Jawaharlal Nehru debate Islamic solidarity and religious orthodoxy



TOWARDS THE END of his life, in 1938, when he had gone almost entirely blind and was dependent on the help of an assistant even for the most moderate of tasks, Muhammad Iqbal, the great Muslim philosopher, sent for Jawaharlal Nehru upon hearing that the latter was in Lahore. Nehru remembered this meeting fondly in his autobiography, framing his visit to Iqbal’s modest two-storey house in a leafy neighbourhood as a reunification of two old friends bonding over their shared socialist convictions.

As calling Iqbal a socialist was as controversial then as it is now, Nehru went on to justify his belief in Iqbal’s ideological persuasion in some detail. He speculated that it might have been ‘the great progress that Soviet Russia had made’ in the 1930s that had moved Iqbal to abandon Sufi mysticism and embrace plain materialism.[1] Nehru insisted that Iqbal’s shift to socialism was visible in his later poetry and prose, at least for the careful reader. He further claimed that Iqbal had realized that a separate Muslim state on Indian soil was not a viable solution to counter Muslim backwardness. Iqbal was aware of ‘its inherent danger and absurdity’.[2]